

# Answer — Connection Checklist

Everything to plug in — API keys, services, and secrets — to take the platform from demo data to a fully active, real-data system.

19 environment variables · 5 AI providers · storage · secrets · email · Last updated 14 Sep 2026

**How activation works.** Every capability turns on the moment its environment variable is set on the deployment (Vercel → Project → Settings → Environment Variables → redeploy). Nothing needs a code change. The **Settings** → **Integrations** page in the app shows each provider as Connected / Not connected and has a **Test connection** button that makes one live call to verify a key.

## 1 · Required to activate (foundation)

| What                 | Variable(s)                                                                                                                                       | What it enables                                                                                                                                                                              | Where to get it / cost                                                            |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hosting              | —                                                                                                                                                 | Deploy the codebase under your own account; connect the <code>useanswer.com</code> domain.                                                                                                   | Vercel (GitHub auto-deploy). Pro plan for commercial use (~\$20/mo).              |
| Durable storage      | <code>KV_REST_API_URL</code><br><code>KV_REST_API_TOKEN</code><br>or <code>UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_URL</code><br><code>UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_TOKEN</code> | <b>Persistence for everything</b> — user sessions, leads, prompts, actions, crawler telemetry, and the sampler's collected answers. Without it, data lives in memory and resets on restarts. | Upstash Redis (free tier) or Vercel Marketplace Redis. Copy the REST URL + token. |
| Demo gate passphrase | <code>DEMO_PASSWORD</code>                                                                                                                        | Rotates the shared demo login (default <code>answer-demo</code> , email <code>dana@nike.com</code> ).                                                                                        | Choose any value. \$0.                                                            |
| Ingest secret        | <code>ANSWR_INGEST_SECRET</code>                                                                                                                  | Hardens the AI-crawler telemetry endpoints so only your own site can write events.                                                                                                           | Generate a random string. \$0.                                                    |
| Cron secret          | <code>CRON_SECRET</code>                                                                                                                          | <b>Arms the nightly sampler</b> — the scheduled job that runs your prompts across the connected AI models and stores the answers. It refuses to run without this.                            | Generate a random string. \$0.                                                    |

## 2 · AI providers — the real numbers

At least **one** is required; each additional provider adds another model to visibility and share-of-voice. The platform queries **every** configured provider automatically.

| Provider           | Variable(s)                                                                                         | Powers                                                                                                  | Where to get it · cost · notes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google Gemini      | GEMINI_API_KEY<br>optional GEMINI_MODEL                                                             | Gemini answer lane;<br>onboarding brand<br>detection; AI<br>competitor/topic<br>suggestions; live scan. | <a href="https://aistudio.google.com">aistudio.google.com</a> → Get API key.<br>Free tier exists but has a <b>daily cap that is per-project</b> — <b>enable billing on the Google Cloud project</b> for reliable use (pennies/day). Default model <code>gemini-3.6-flash</code> .        |
| OpenAI (ChatGPT)   | OPENAI_API_KEY<br>optional OPENAI_MODEL                                                             | ChatGPT answer lane<br>with web-search<br>citations.                                                    | <a href="https://platform.openai.com">platform.openai.com</a> → API keys → create a <b>project key</b> ( <code>sk-proj-...</code> ). The org needs billing/credits. Paste keys <b>directly into Vercel</b> — keys exposed in chats/repos get auto-revoked. Default <code>gpt-4o</code> . |
| Anthropic (Claude) | ANTHROPIC_API_KEY<br>optional ANTHROPIC_MODEL                                                       | Claude answer lane;<br>Haiku sentiment<br>classification.                                               | <a href="https://console.anthropic.com">console.anthropic.com</a> → API keys.<br>Usage-based (Haiku is very cheap).                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Perplexity         | PERPLEXITY_API_KEY<br>optional<br>PERPLEXITY_MODEL                                                  | Sonar answer lane with<br>native citations (best<br>citation quality).                                  | <a href="https://perplexity.ai">perplexity.ai</a> → API. ~\$2–5/mo at pilot volume.                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DataForSEO         | DATAFORSEO_LOGIN<br>DATAFORSEO_PASSWORD<br>optional<br>DATAFORSEO_LOCATION ,<br>DATAFORSEO_LANGUAGE | <b>Google AI Overviews</b><br>(the only official path) +<br>search-demand<br>volume.                    | <a href="https://dataforseo.com">dataforseo.com</a> → API credentials. \$50 minimum funding, then pay-per-use.                                                                                                                                                                           |

**Recommended minimum for a real-data test:** Gemini (with billing enabled) — it alone powers onboarding detection, AI suggestions, the live scan, and the sampler. Add OpenAI/Anthropic/Perplexity to compare across models. Add DataForSEO only if you want Google AI Overviews coverage.

## 3 · Email & leads

| What   | Variable(s)                                            | What it enables                                                                                | Where to get it / cost                                                                                        |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Resend | RESEND_API_KEY<br>LEAD_NOTIFY_EMAIL<br>LEAD_FROM_EMAIL | Emails you each captured lead (demo, snapshot, waitlist forms) and powers transactional email. | <a href="https://resend.com">resend.com</a> → API key; verify your sending domain. Free tier (~3k emails/mo). |

Leads are captured and stored regardless (Settings → Leads); Resend only adds the email notification.

## 4 · Where real data appears once keys are in — and what still needs a short build

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Being precise so the test matches expectations:

| Surface                                           | With keys connected                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Onboarding (steps 1–3)                            | <b>Real</b> — detects the brand from a URL, suggests competitors and a topic set from the live model.                                                                                                                                |
| Live Scan ( <code>/app/scan</code> )              | <b>Real</b> — queries every configured model live; shows genuine visibility, share of voice, ranking, and what each model said.                                                                                                      |
| Add-a-brand → Suggest with AI                     | <b>Real</b> — AI competitor suggestions.                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Nightly sampler + scoring                         | <b>Real</b> — collects real answers on schedule (needs <code>CRON_SECRET</code> + storage); <code>/api/scoring/preview</code> scores them.                                                                                           |
| Live telemetry ( <code>/app/live</code> )         | <b>Real</b> — AI crawlers hitting the site (durable with storage; hardened with the ingest secret).                                                                                                                                  |
| Leads (Settings → Leads)                          | <b>Real</b> — captured and stored; emailed with Resend.                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Main dashboards (Overview / Insights / Citations) | <b>Sample data until a short build</b> — wire the scoring engine's output into these views (the engine exists; see <code>LAUNCH_ROADMAP.md B2</code> ). Multi-tenant workspaces and billing (Stripe) are also build items, not keys. |

## 5 · Setup order (about an hour)

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1. **Deploy** the repo to your own Vercel account and point `useanswr.com` at it.
2. **Add storage** — create an Upstash Redis DB, set the two `KV_REST_API_*` (or `UPSTASH_*`) vars. Persistence is now on.
3. **Set the secrets** — `DEMO_PASSWORD` , `ANSWR_INGEST_SECRET` , `CRON_SECRET` .
4. **Add at least one AI key** — Gemini with billing enabled is the recommended start. Redeploy.
5. **Verify** — Settings → Integrations → **Test connection** on each provider (green = live).
6. **See real numbers** — open `/app/scan` , enter any brand, click **Run live scan**.
7. **Add email** (Resend) and **more providers** as desired — each activates on its own.

## 6 • Quick reference — all 19 variables

| Variable                                                             | Group            | Required?                 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>KV_REST_API_URL / KV_REST_API_TOKEN</b>                           | Storage          | Yes (or the Upstash pair) |
| <b>UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_URL / UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_TOKEN</b>             | Storage (alt)    | Alternative to KV pair    |
| <b>DEMO_PASSWORD</b>                                                 | Secrets          | Recommended               |
| <b>ANSWR_INGEST_SECRET</b>                                           | Secrets          | Recommended               |
| <b>CRON_SECRET</b>                                                   | Secrets          | Yes, for the sampler      |
| <b>GEMINI_API_KEY (+ GEMINI_MODEL)</b>                               | AI provider      | At least one provider     |
| <b>OPENAI_API_KEY (+ OPENAI_MODEL)</b>                               | AI provider      | Optional                  |
| <b>ANTHROPIC_API_KEY (+ ANTHROPIC_MODEL)</b>                         | AI provider      | Optional                  |
| <b>PERPLEXITY_API_KEY (+ PERPLEXITY_MODEL)</b>                       | AI provider      | Optional                  |
| <b>DATAFORSEO_LOGIN / DATAFORSEO_PASSWORD (+ LOCATION, LANGUAGE)</b> | AI/SERP provider | Optional (AI Overviews)   |
| <b>RESEND_API_KEY / LEAD_NOTIFY_EMAIL / LEAD_FROM_EMAIL</b>          | Email            | Optional                  |

No key is ever committed to the repository; all live in the deployment environment. Full technical detail: `HANDOFF.md` and the Technical Documentation.